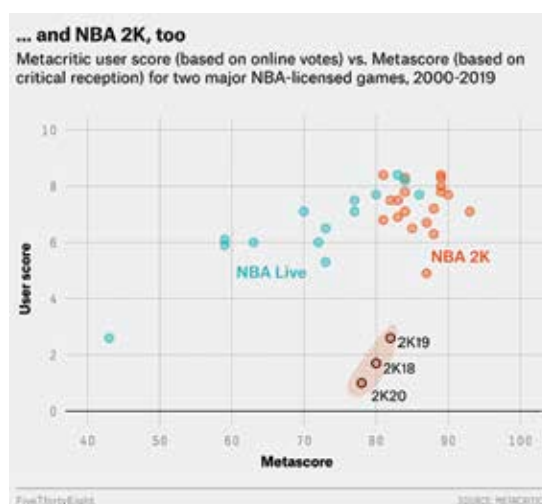


Source: Metacritic



The difference is apparent

es EA billions of dollars from its customers. These players, despite knowing the fact that they are being served the same repurposed game, flock to place pre-orders and buy copies of games as soon as they are announced.

However, here is also where the contrarian, pro-consumer argument comes in. In FIFA, there is an Ultimate Team mode that, according to the stats published by EA in its annual report (2020), makes up 29 per cent of the company's total income.

The company could very well make up for its loss in sales from its yearly releases by pushing out more features over their Ultimate Team section. This would also make the players happy by serving them a single long-term solution to their gaming needs! There are many reasons other than just the happiness of the

game, gets even stronger. In the actual sport, rules seldom change, and the players' play style is anyways defined by the human controlling the player in the game. So, what is the need to launch a new sports game?

Let's take the example of EA Cricket. Remember that franchise? It's dead now, for a good reason. The last instalment of EA Cricket was released in 2007, and there has been nothing after that. This is majorly because it had everything. Cricket could be played in 50, 20, 10, and 5 overs formats, which in itself was enough. All of the iconic venues of the sport were present, and apart from the graphics, and some of the game physics, there was not much left to be changed. The same is the case with the FIFA franchise.

If we look at it objectively, only the player rosters for every team need to be changed year over year. After years of development, the game physics is almost polished, and in terms of the rules, the sport of football also hasn't seen much change. That reflects in the releases by EA every year. Thousands of fans complain about the game majorly being the same as it was in 2020. The only thing that is keeping the fran-

fans that should motivate the companies to shift their focus towards making a sports game which sees incremental updates instead of launching a new title every year.

Do they change?

When dealing with sports games, the argument about making a single long-lasting title that gets a periodic update to improve the



Brings a smile to the face. Doesn't it?

chise afloat is the sheer number of fans of the sport. If football had been a sport with a player base as small as cricket, then the FIFA games would have suffered the same fate as their cricket counterpart by now.

What's next?

As we mentioned earlier, the solution to the problem of stagnation and lack of diversity in the sports game industry is to ensure that studios release a single well-maintained game. They can make up for the revenue lost out in sales of new iterations of games by pushing the sales of in-game items. Instead of selling an entirely new game, whose only unique selling point is that it has a new stadium and a new team kit, companies can make DLCs out of these items and sell them as an addon download. Further expansion, like Counter-Strike did with its skins, can also be a great way for companies to make money. CS:GO, a completely free-to-play title, in 2018, made 414 million dollars in terms of revenue. Since then, the numbers have grown, indicating that there is a solution out there. The only thing that remains is for the development studios to take notice and bring in a change that actually makes the players happy. *

